

Khaled Hosseini's *A Thousand Splendid Suns*

feminist literary lens



Song: "I am Woman" by Helen
Reddy

I am woman, hear me roar

In numbers too big to ignore

And I know too much

To go back and pretend

Cause I've heard it all before

And I've been down there on the floor

No one's ever gonna keep me down again

Oh yes, I am wise

But it's wisdom born of pain

Yes, I've paid the price

But look how much I gained

If I have to, I can do anything

I am strong, I am invincible

I am woman

I am woman, watch me grow

See me standing toe-to-toe

As I spread my loving arms across the land

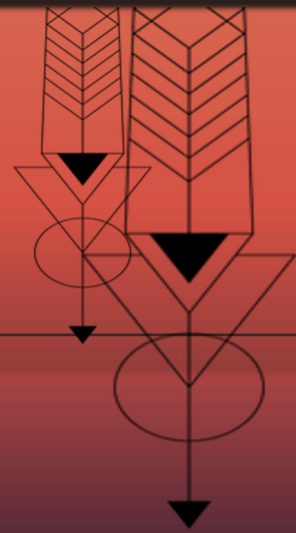
But I'm still an embryo

With a long, long way to go

Until I make my brothers understand

An abstract geometric diagram in the top right corner, featuring a central vertical axis with an upward-pointing arrow. This axis is flanked by two vertical rectangular blocks, each containing a series of horizontal lines. Above these blocks are two circles, each with a vertical line passing through its center. The entire diagram is composed of black outlines on a yellow-to-orange gradient background.

... Feminist Literary Criticism ...

An abstract geometric diagram in the bottom left corner, featuring a central vertical axis with a downward-pointing arrow. This axis is flanked by two vertical rectangular blocks, each containing a series of horizontal lines. Below these blocks are two circles, each with a vertical line passing through its center. The entire diagram is composed of black outlines on a red-to-purple gradient background.

definition

- literary analysis based from the viewpoint of feminism, feminist theory, and/or feminist politics
- explores the portrayal of women in literature
- views society and culture as mainly patriarchal, or male-dominated



(Napikoski)

definition

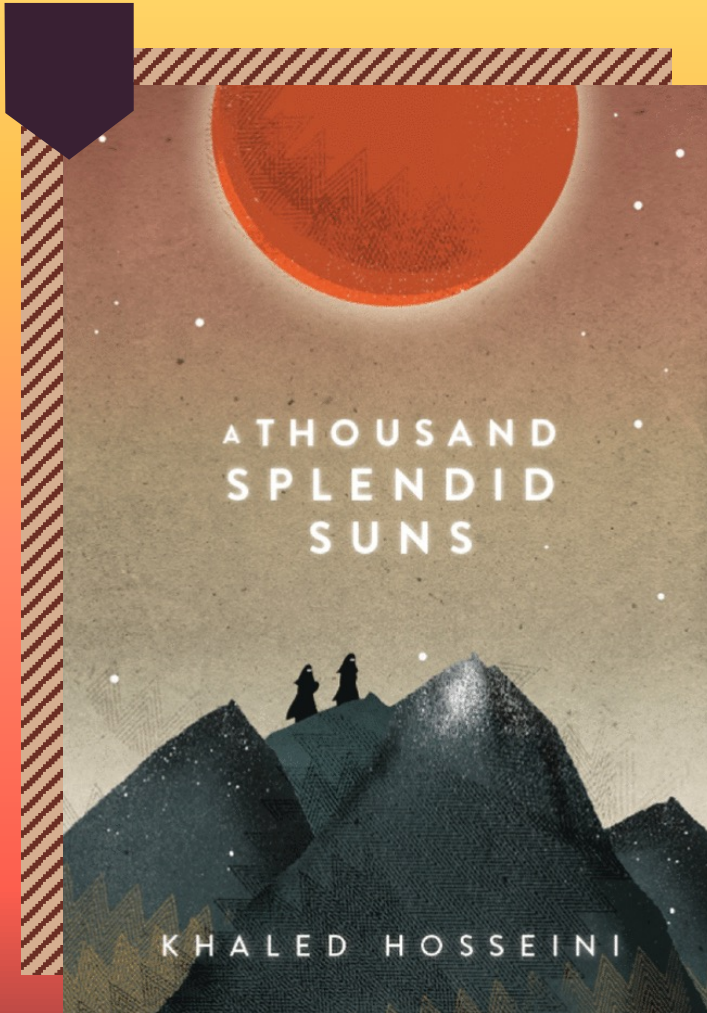
Common approaches:

1. Women are oppressed by patriarchy
2. Where patriarchy prevails is where a woman becomes marginalized
3. Culture determines gender
4. Gender equality is the goal of feminism



(Tyson)

plot summary



Main Characters

Setting

Conflict

Themes



Place : Afghanistan - Kabul, Herat, and Gul Daman

Time : from early 1970s to early 2000s

(video: What's Life Like for Women in Afghanistan -
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tdlEhOqSnUA>)





Mariam : daughter of Jalil, a wealthy businessman, and Nana, his servant; married to Rasheed at 15

Laila : daughter of Hakim and Fariba;
aspires to use her intelligence to change
the world around her; married to
Rasheed at 14





Person vs Self

Mariam vs. **Herself**

- striving for love, affection, and acceptance
- blaming herself for her mother's death





Person vs Person

Mariam and Laila vs. **Rasheed**

- physical and emotional abuse
- Rasheed as a cruel, violent, and manipulative husband
- always blames his wives for his misfortunes





Person vs Society

Mariam and Laila vs. **The Patriarchal Society of Afghanistan**

- strict Shari'a laws by the Taliban
- diminishing of women's rights
- unequal privileges for men and women





Abuse of
Power

Women and
Femininity

Men and
Masculinity

Gender
Roles and
Relations

Warfare and
Conflict



From the perspective of feminist literary criticism, the novel *A Thousand Splendid Suns* by Khaled Hosseini depicts the inferior role and cruel treatment of women under the patriarchal society in Afghanistan. Although Afghan women in the story are deemed to be victims of harsh circumstances in the hands of men, nevertheless the author portrays them to be exceptionally courageous and enduring. The oppression of women and their response are portrayed through the main characters' social and psychological stature throughout the novel.



POINT NO.1 - THE OPPRESSION OF WOMEN IN AFGHANISTAN

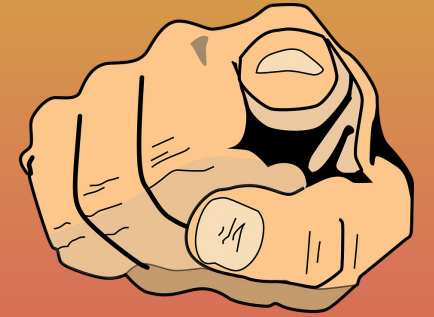




“Learn this now and learn it well, my daughter: Like a compass needle that points north, a man's accusing finger always finds a woman.” (Hosseini 7)



- Nana to Mariam
- Jalil refuses to take responsibility of fatherhood
- Mariam and Rasheed's abusive marriage
- Rasheed always blaming Mariam





*“You try this again and I will find you...There isn't a court
in this godforsaken country that will hold me accountable
for what I will do.” (272)*



- Mariam and Laila's failed escape
- Rasheed's threat
- Theme: Abuse of Power
- not to be held accountable because the law favours him
- deprivation of rights for women





POINT NO. 2 - THE INNER STRENGTH OF WOMEN AS DEPICTED THROUGH THE MAIN CHARACTERS





“There is only one, only one skill a woman like you and me needs in life...And it's this: *tahamul*. Endure...It's our lot in life, Mariam. Women like us. We endure .” (18)



- oppression of Afghan women
- endurance and courage
- physical and emotional abuse
- harsh reality of a woman's fate and role in a highly patriarchal society

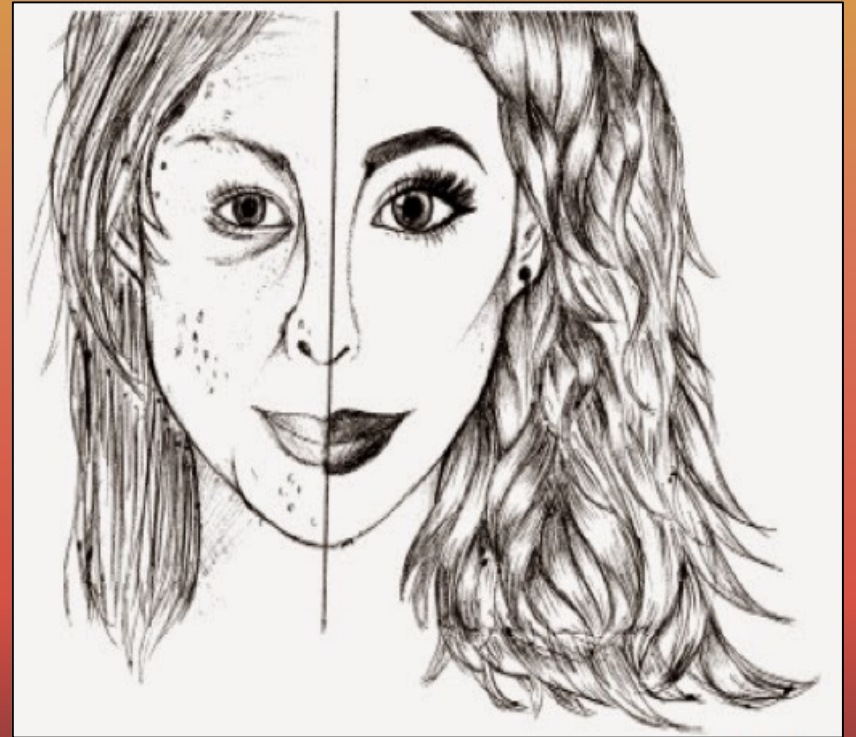




“This little girl will be a woman who will make small demands on life, who will never burden others, who will never let on that she too has had sorrows, disappointments, dreams that have been ridiculed.” (401)



- Laila dreams about Mariam
- highlights the sacrifices that a woman makes, especially to prevent further suffering for the people she loves
- Mariam's courage to accept her fate





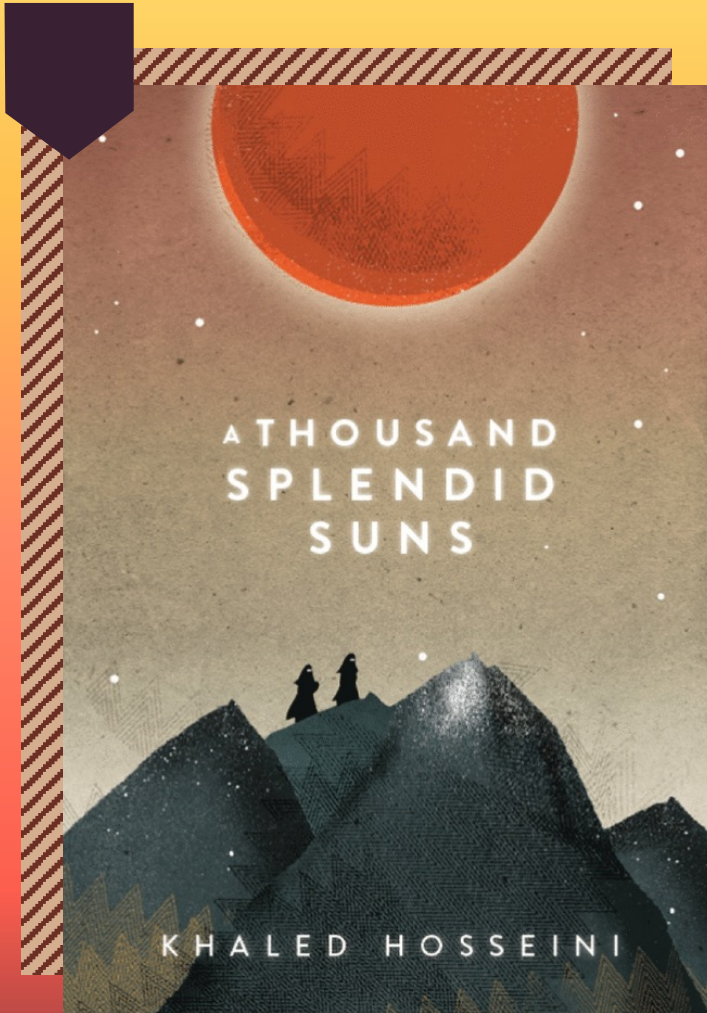
Thesis

- feminist literary theory
- role and treatment of women
- portrayal of the female characters

Main Points

- the awful realities that women face in a male-dominated world
- the inner qualities that enables women to survive

final thoughts



Likes

Dislikes

Interesting Points

Recommendations